Time, Temperature

By Jim Daniels

INTRODUCTION

A predominantly Black city, Detroit has a long history of police brutality, housing inequality and racial struggles. In 1947, a brawl broke out between a white and black man in downtown Detroit. Igniting existing racial tensions, it resulted in a 24-hour riot and the deaths of 25 African - Americans and nine whites. Over twenty years later, Detroit was home to one of the most violent urban revolts in the 20th century – the Detroit Race Riot of 1967. Today, Detroit is still one of the poorest cities in the United States, and according to many the racial tensions have been resolved. In Time, Temperature Jim Daniels takes on the 1943 and 1967 Detroit riots and the continued pervasiveness of racism even within his own family.

1967, Detroit. My grandfather watches
Tracer bullets zing past
His window. The National Guard's taken over
Lillibridge School on the corner.

He remembers the strike at Packard
when they promoted blacks,
Then the riots in '43,

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How the crowds gathered on Belle Isle
just down the road, all the bloodshed
just down the road.

On the phone with my father, he is saying *niggers*
And my father is saying *Dad* he is saying
Dad stay in the house, stay away from the window.

My grandfather has his theories
why they can't take the cold
Can't skate can't swim
why they can't park their cars
why grape's their favorite flavor
Why if you get bit by one with purple lips
it will kill you.

My father shakes his head into thick air
saying *stay away, stay away.*
A drop of sweat hits the dirty kitchen floor.
Dad, Dad. My father's long sigh.

◆

Eenie, meanie miney moe
catch a nigger by the toe
our toes wedged in a tight circle
to see who'd be It. My mother
wouldn't let us say *nigger.*
She said say *froggy.*

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We said *froggy*. The other kids said
froggy?

She washed my mouth with soap.
Where did you hear that word?
Everywhere. *Where?*

◆

1967. Eleven, I climbed on the garage
with my father's camera. In the streaked photos
flocks of helicopters blotch the sky, nothing
like birds. I held on to the rough shingles
as the spinning blades roared above me.
Helicopters spilled guardsmen
onto the armory lawn on Eight Mile Road,
the border between Detroit and Warren.

We lived on that edge. Sirens
wailed their crazy tune, no Motown Sound,
nothing we could dance to.

Fear of heights seemed more real
than what I heard on the radio, than rumors
panting on the street: *They're at Belmont.*
They're at Farwell Field.
They're crossing Eight Mile.

Getting up was easy. I needed help

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getting down, my feet dangling in air,
the camera somersaulting down onto the grass.

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Eight Mile Road. Six lanes wide. The long barbed
shout, pale slab, sizzling fuse.

I didn't know a black person till I was nineteen.
I could have almost shouted from my porch.

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Nigger pile. Riding nigger.
Nigger pile on Tony. Nigger beard.
Nigger stompers. Nigger-rigged.
Nigger-lipped. Niggered up. Nigger toes.
Niger Heaven. How far
you have to chase that nigger
to get that shirt? A fight, a fight
a nigger and a white.

Should I explain the terms, include an index
and glossary? Do we all possess
such footnotes, filed, hidden, backwards,
in code, watermarks revealed by light?

Plenty of words for hate around here.
Like Eskimos with snow, we have
our subtle distinctions.

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Our fathers worked with their fathers
in factories in Detroit and Warren,
Brought their hate home in greasy lunch pails:
better watch out for that nigger.
That's a nigger department.
Don't help that nigger,
lazy nigger.

It spilled across the dinner tables,
through the muddy alleys,
across the concrete playgrounds,
into the schools, and we learned
our lessons well.

◆

1974. Black students
from Pershing High two miles away
visited Fitzgerald, my school.
We asked them questions
in a room crowded with teachers
who prompted us in whispers.
So foreign even those translators couldn't help.
Stilted as a high-school play.
Someone took pictures for the yearbook.

They filled our halls with a flavor
foreign and pungent. Some new kind of cooking

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I wasn't sure about.
The next day in class we sat glum
while a perky teacher preached brotherhood.
We knew better. *They only brought*
the nice ones, somebody said.

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1975. I worked in a liquor store
where we didn't cash checks for blacks
but sold them booze and cigarettes.

A man held a gun to my head
where's your hiding place
*where's your ***** hiding place?*
I said we don't have a hiding place
he said *****, *everybody*
got a hiding place
I said we took it to the bank
he said *I'm gonna kill you ********
where's your hiding place?

We stood there, his gun brushing my temple.
We looked each other in the eye: no recognition.
He grabbed money from the register,
took off down Eight Mile. I reached down
and fingered the cigarette carton
filled with checks and twenties.
the boss called the cops.

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Fingerprints on a can of Colt .45
and no clues or suspects.
Colt .45, I said, *figures.*

I flipped through the mug shots:
some nigger, I said.

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Carl the gun collector
handed out rifles to the neighbors
in '67: *just in case just in case*
they cross Eight Mile. To protect
our families and homes, he said.
The right to bear arms.
My father did not take one.

In 1974 under the threat of busing
neighbors took pledges
put signs in their windows
I will not send my kids.
I will keep my kids home.
My mother took no sign.

The Supreme Court ruled against
cross-district busing.
Neighbors smiled archly
no thanks to you, as if my mother

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was a scab in this union town.

◆

1980. In the department store,
those foam packing chips that last forever
poured from an overhead funnel
into gift boxes full

Kim's dark skin
surrounded by the white, white foam.
Where all the black people worked,
along with me and another white kid.

We felt like robots down there,
filling and sealing. Till our eyes locked
in the hard stare of mannequins.
We ate lunch together
in the lounge. People talked.
It only took me a year to ask her out.
Dixie scowled. *What are you doing?*
This is Detroit you're talking about.

We went to a movie in my part of town,
for coffee in her part.
I can't remember what we saw
because I held her hand in the dark
and we were alone there just like
two white kids, or two black kids.

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All night the stares bit into us
like tiny bugs we couldn't see.
Walking to the car, I squeezed
her hand into a fist.
I guess you have to be rich
to get away with it, she said
and maybe she was right.

In her apartment, her child cried
upstairs while we held each other on the couch.

Go home white boy, somebody yelled
when I go in my car.

◆

I said *some nigger robbed the store*
and the copy said *What else is new?*
Get a gun, he said.
The board tilts, and all the balls
roll into the same hole.

I felt bad, but I said it anyway.
My shrunken head, tiny eyes
sewn shut. There is no
immunization, no shot, no cure,
no pill, no magic, no saint,

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no argument, no prophet,
no potion, no confession,
no gift, no miracle, no ***** miracle.

No.

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Last summer, the dog next door
scared away two black kids
trying to break into my basement.

I saw them running away. A week later
the same two kids cased out a house
down the street. I stood at the door
watching, sweating, heart jumping.

I stepped out toward them. They said
You keep following us you're gonna get hurt.
I said *I'm only trying to protect my property.*
They said *Listen man, you wanna get hurt?*

No, I don't want to get hurt.
Yes, I have property now,
An old house in this mixed neighborhood.
Maybe I was afraid because they were black.
Maybe they were angry because I was white.
I tried to talk calmly but I know enough
about being stoned to know

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they were stoned on something.
Everybody stoned on something --
Stoned on history and hate.

Everybody got a hiding place.

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Carl took his guns back
but they are someplace.
Carl moved away
but he is someplace.

I know Carl. His nose twitches
with the gunpowder of his own hate.

They are someplace.

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I am trying to be naïve.

An open fire hydrant in hot August
after an afternoon game at Tiger Stadium.
I am walking toward my car.
A young black kid, maybe six, is dancing
in his underwear in the cool spray
he is holding his wrists up toward the sky
as if to say *take me, take me like this*
and I am so hot I join him

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dancing too in cutoffs and T-shirt

And I raise my arms above my head
thinking *yes, I would like to be taken like this*
and we dance under the same sun
and there is room enough for both of us
in the spray on Rosa Parks Boulevard
in Detroit in Michigan in America

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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